

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 7

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator, a teenager, becomes separated from her family in an unfamiliar foreign city and must find her way back to them.

1

The doors of the metro carriage hissed shut a heartbeat before I could reach them. Through the smeared glass, I watched my mother's face slide past, her mouth opening around a word I could not hear, her hand still half-raised as though she might, by sheer will, pull the train back to the platform. My father was already turning towards the guard. My little brother was crying. Then the tunnel swallowed them, and the carriage I stood in lurched forward into the dark, and I was very suddenly, very completely, alone.

2

I told myself, in the firm voice I used on my brother when he was frightened of dogs, that this was not a disaster. I had a phone. I had the name of our hotel written on a scrap of paper in my pocket. I had, somewhere in the bottom of my bag, the equivalent of about twenty euros in unfamiliar coins. I was fifteen years old, not five. I would get off at the next stop, cross to the opposite platform, and take the next train back. The plan was so reasonable that, for a moment, I almost believed it.

3

At the next stop I stepped out, and the plan began, quietly, to come apart. The signs above me marched past in a script I could not read — beautiful, looping letters that meant nothing to my eye. The map on the wall was a tangle of coloured lines, each one labelled in the same unreadable alphabet. I fished out my phone to check the route. The screen was black. I pressed the side button. Nothing. I pressed it harder, as if force might restore what neglect had drained. The phone, dead since some unnoticed moment that morning, looked back at me indifferently.

4

That was when the panic, which had been waiting patiently in my chest, stood up and began to walk around. I tried to remember the name of the hotel. I could see the room in my mind, the floral curtains, the tap that dripped — but the name on the front, the one stitched into the bath mats, would not

come. The scrap of paper, I now remembered, had been left on the bedside table that morning, because I had thought, with the lazy confidence of a tourist, that I would not need it. People hurried past me in both directions, talking to each other, talking into phones, none of them looking at me. The station felt suddenly enormous, and I felt suddenly very small.

5

I climbed the stairs out of the metro because I could not bear to stand still any longer. The street above was hotter and louder than I had expected. Scooters wove between cars; a market spilled across the pavement; the air smelled of frying oil and unfamiliar spice. I sat down on the kerb beside a row of plastic stools and a low cart that I dimly understood to be a tea stall. I think I was trying not to cry. I do not think I was succeeding.

6

“You are lost.”

The voice was quiet, in careful English, and it belonged to the woman behind the cart. She was perhaps my grandmother’s age, with grey hair pinned back and her sleeves rolled to the elbow. She did not phrase it as a question. She pushed a small glass of milky tea across the cart towards me, and when I shook my head and reached for the coins in my bag, she made a small, dismissive gesture with one hand, as if money were beneath the present situation. “Drink. Then we think.” Her English was slow but it was the most welcome sound I had heard all day.

7

She let me sit on one of her plastic stools. She let me describe the hotel — the floral curtains, the dripping tap, the small square sign with a blue elephant on it that I had, with a jolt of relief, finally remembered. She nodded once, as if a blue elephant were the most ordinary landmark in the world, and turned to the old man at the next stool, and the two of them talked for what felt like a long time. Then she wrote, in patient block letters on the back of a paper napkin, the name of my hotel in her own script and in mine, and the name of the metro stop I needed, and the number of the line. “Show this,” she said, pressing the napkin into my hand, “if you forget.”

8

Forty minutes later I came up the steps of a metro station I had never seen before, and there, on the other side of the road, was a blue elephant on a square sign, and beneath it my father, pacing, his phone pressed to his ear, his eyes scanning the crowd. He saw me before I could call out. He did not run, exactly — my father does not run — but he crossed that road faster than I had ever seen him move. My mother came out of the hotel doorway a moment later, and my brother behind her, still red-eyed. I have never, before or since, been hugged so hard. Somewhere in my pocket, folded very small, was a paper napkin I have never thrown away.

From Paragraph 1

1. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show the moment of separation happened very quickly. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. Explain, in your own words, why the narrator says her plan was “so reasonable that, for a moment, I almost believed it.” What does this tell us about how she really felt? [2]

From Paragraph 3

3. The narrator says she pressed the side button of the phone “harder, as if force might restore what neglect had drained.” What does this action reveal about her state of mind? [2]

4. The narrator writes that the phone “looked back at me indifferently.” What is **unusual** about this description, and what effect does it create? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator describes the panic as having “stood up and began to walk around.” Explain how this language makes the panic seem like a living thing. [2]

6. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 that shows the narrator now feels small and helpless in the station. [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator writes: “I think I was trying not to cry. I do not think I was succeeding.”

(a) What does the **short, repeated sentence structure** suggest about her emotional state? [1]

(b) Why might the writer have chosen not to say plainly that the narrator was crying? [1]

From Paragraph 6

8. The tea-stall owner says, “Drink. Then we think.” Explain what these **short sentences** suggest about her character. [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator says the woman “nodded once, as if a blue elephant were the most ordinary landmark in the world.” What does this comparison tell us about the woman’s manner towards the narrator? [2]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says of her father: “He did not run, exactly — my father does not run — but he crossed that road faster than I had ever seen him move.” What impression of her father does this give us? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the hidden cost of fast fashion.****1**

A T-shirt that costs less than a sandwich is, on the face of it, a small miracle of modern commerce. Yet behind that two-pound price tag lies one of the most polluting and exploitative industries on the planet. “Fast fashion” — the business of designing, producing and selling enormous volumes of cheap clothing at breakneck speed — has, in the last twenty years, transformed the way the world dresses. Global clothing production has roughly doubled since the year 2000, and the average garment is now worn fewer than ten times before being thrown away. The numbers are dazzling. The cost, as a growing body of evidence makes plain, is anything but small.

2

Consider, first, the water. It takes around 2,700 litres of water to produce a single cotton T-shirt — roughly the amount one person drinks in two and a half years. The dyeing and finishing of textiles is, by some estimates, responsible for a fifth of all industrial water pollution worldwide. Then there are the microplastics: every time a synthetic garment is washed, it sheds tiny plastic fibres which slip through filters, drift down rivers, and have now been found in the deepest trenches of the ocean, in Arctic snow, and inside human blood. The garment that costs a customer two pounds, in other words, is paid for several times over by ecosystems that send no invoice.

3

Then there is the question of what happens after the garment is worn. The average consumer throws away clothing equivalent to the weight of eighty T-shirts every year. Only about one per cent of discarded clothing is genuinely recycled into new fabric; the rest is incinerated, sent to landfill, or — more uncomfortably — shipped abroad to be sorted in countries with weaker waste regulations. In one well-documented case, satellite imagery has revealed mountain ranges of unwanted Western clothing accumulating in the Atacama Desert in Chile, where they slowly bleach in the sun, leach dye into the soil, and, occasionally, catch fire.

4

The human cost is no less troubling. Around eighty per cent of garment workers worldwide are women, and many are paid below a living wage. Investigations by labour rights groups have documented sixty-hour weeks, locked fire exits, and managers who deduct wages for “talking” or “taking too long” in the bathroom. The collapse of the Rana Plaza factory in Bangladesh in 2013, which killed more than a thousand workers, prompted a wave of pledges from international brands. A decade on, audits remain patchy, sub-contracting is rampant, and the cheapest end of the market — increasingly dominated by online “ultra-fast” retailers — has if anything pushed conditions further into the shadows.

5

Against this gloomy backdrop, a small but striking counter-trend has emerged: resale. Platforms such as Vinted, Depop and ThredUp now allow consumers to buy and sell second-hand clothing as easily as ordering takeaway. The global resale market was valued at around \$197 billion in 2023 and is projected to grow roughly three times faster than the wider fashion industry. For some shoppers, particularly younger ones, buying second-hand has shed its old, slightly apologetic image and become not only acceptable but quietly fashionable. There is a real environmental gain here: every garment that finds a second wearer is one that did not need to be manufactured from scratch.

6

And yet it would be naive to imagine that resale alone can solve the problem. Researchers have begun to warn of a “rebound effect”: shoppers, reassured that they can recoup some of their spending later, simply buy more in the first place. Some platforms have themselves been criticised for accepting bulk

listings from fast-fashion brands, blurring the line between resale and ordinary retail. Individual consumer action, in any case, has its limits. A shopper who carefully washes synthetics in a microfibre-catching bag, buys second-hand, and mends a torn seam is still operating inside a system whose default settings — overproduction, underpayment, planned disposability — remain unchanged.

7

What is needed, then, is structural change as well as personal effort: extended-producer-responsibility laws that force brands to pay for the disposal of what they make; binding wage and safety standards along the supply chain; bans on the destruction of unsold stock, of the sort recently introduced in France. None of this absolves the individual shopper, who can still choose to buy less, wear longer and waste less. But it does shift the moral weight of the problem from the wardrobe to the boardroom, where, in truth, most of the real decisions are made.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer calls a cheap T-shirt “a small miracle of modern commerce.” Explain, in your own words, why he describes it this way, and what tone the description carries. [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, give **two** pieces of evidence that show the **scale** of the fast-fashion industry. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. Why does the writer compare the water needed to make a single T-shirt to “the amount one person drinks in two and a half years”? [2]

15. The writer says the cheap garment “is paid for several times over by ecosystems that send no invoice.” Explain, in your own words, what he means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 3

16. The writer puts the word “recycled” in inverted commas earlier in the text, but here he writes about clothing that is “genuinely recycled.” Why does he use the word **genuinely**? [1]

17. Why does the writer describe the discarded clothing in the Atacama Desert as forming “mountain ranges”? [2]

From Paragraph 4

18. The writer says that conditions at the cheapest end of the market have been “pushed further into the shadows.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. What is the writer’s **attitude** towards the rise of resale platforms in Paragraph 5? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. Explain, in your own words, what the researchers mean by a “rebound effect.” [2]

21. The writer ends Paragraph 6 by saying that an individual shopper is “still operating inside a system whose default settings — overproduction, underpayment, planned disposability — remain unchanged.” Explain how the writer uses **contrast** in this sentence to make his point. [2]

From Paragraph 7

22. The writer writes that structural change “shift[s] the moral weight of the problem from the wardrobe to the boardroom.” What is **effective** about this contrast? [2]

23. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the harms caused by fast fashion** and **the measures being taken to address them**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 7** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Fast fashion causes harm by ...

— END OF PAPER —